> donkey of their desires into the field of stupidity, to the point of having all of us arrested shortly and deported into foreign imprisonment. I put my trust in God and raise the battle standard of our Prophet Muhammad, and thus go to fight: if success rewards us, then that is as we wished; and if we die in battle, that is still better than to live with degradation and dishonour!' The other Sardars, his childhood friends, tightened their belts and girt their loins and prepared for Jihad – holy war.[92]

When Mohan Lal came to hear about the meeting of the conspirators through his informers, he immediately went over to Burnes's house to warn him of what was brewing. Burnes had spent the day fretting about his future: it was the twentieth anniversary of his first footfall in India and he felt that it must be a life-changing day. 'What will this day bring forth?' reads the last entry in his journal. 'It will make or mar me, I suppose. Before the sun sets I shall know.'[93] But the Ghilzai uprising had blocked the passes, and no post arrived in Kabul that day.

'On the evening of 1st November 1841,' wrote Mohan Lal,

> I visited Sir Alexander Burnes and told him [what was afoot] . . . He replied that he does not like to meddle in the arrangement made by the Envoy, as he goes in a few days to Bombay, and then he [Burnes] will conciliate the chiefs by fixing former allowances. I told him again that it was contrary to the rules of service to allow such unfortunate evils to grow in height and not contrive means to annihilate them before the serious injuries are done to us by the enemies. When he heard this, he stood up from his chair, sighed, then sat back, telling me that the time had already arrived that we should leave this country and lament for the loss of it.[94]

As Mohan Lal was heading back to his house, further down the Pul-i-Khishti Bazaar, the conspirators were preparing for action. 'That very night,' wrote Mirza 'Ata,

> before dawn had broken, they went to the house of Burnes, and with their pitiless swords killed the soldiers that were on guard there. The news of the fight spread through the city and the men of Kabul, sturdy fighters, welcomed it as a gift from God long prayed for. They boarded up their shops, took up arms and ran to the scene shouting [the Durrani and Ghilzai battle cry] 'Ya Chahar Yar! O Four Friends, the rightly-guided Caliphs of Islam!' As dawn was breaking, locust-like, they poured into the streets, and assembled around the house of Alexander Burnes.[95]